Polish?”

“If the father is German, the baby will live.”

“Let us pray to God that he is German.”

“It’s not so simple.”

“Why?”

“The baby will be taken away and raised by a German family.”

“It’s *her* child.”

“As I said, we help her keep the baby a secret—that’s all we can do. Anything else will require a miracle. Do you understand?”

No, she didn’t understand. Not the hierarchy, the classifications, or why the beauty and sanctity of life had been cut and squeezed into artificial categories devoid of meaning. If she heard the Meister or Lagerführer utter *filthy Pole* one more time, she thought she would explode. They did it on repeat, like machines. That’s what they were: automatons, an assembly line spewing out parts—the opposite of creative human beings who were different and unique and couldn’t be placed into categories. They wanted to reduce people to numbers—ones and zeros. Numbers had no dignity and could be easily shuffled around and discarded. Léa was lost. None of it was real, and yet all of it was horribly real. She couldn’t just watch it all unfold; she wanted to do more. She feared that not doing anything would make her a machine like them.

She looked up into his deep brown eyes. “Tell me how to help her. What can I do?”

“She needs more food, better nutrition. I’m guessing she’s four months along. It’s a critical stage for the baby.”

How could she arrange for this? Léa’s food ration coupons were hardly enough for her, but with her wages, she was able to buy food on the black market to supplement them. She knew that Maria and the other Polish women earned much less. She would find a way, even if it meant giving her rations to Maria, because a baby was innocent and needed protection. It was the least that Léa could do.

She glanced at the typewriter. He said he would keep the pregnancy out of the report. But who received the reports?

“The patient reports I type every night, where are they sent?” she asked.

“To Herr Reinhardt at the Gestapo office across from the church.”